In The Dock

The trial of Erich Honecker and five co-defendants – Erich Mielke, Willi Stoph, Heinz Kessler, Fritz Streletz and Hans Albrecht – described by the Berliner Zeitung as the ‘largest legal process in German post-war history’ – began at the Berlin regional court on 12 November 1992.

As the media frenzy developed, it was widely pointed out that excluding Hitler’s successor, Admiral Dönitz – Honecker was the first German head-of-state to be put on trial in over 800 years.1

Before proceedings opened, Honecker’s chief defence lawyer, Friedrich Wolff, told reporters:

The Berlin Wall was not built by the initiative of anyone in Germany, but by order of Soviet leaders in Moscow. It was a symptom of a political confrontation that has now ended. You can condemn these defendants politically or morally, and historians may also judge them harshly. But they acted under the laws of a country that was internationally recognised, and today’s Germany has no legal right to put them on trial.2

On entering the court at 9.30am, Honecker scanned the public gallery for a friendly face. After a few seconds, his eyes laid on a young man thrusting his fist skyward in a gesture – he then shouted: ‘Hello Erich. Red Front. We will win, not them.’ Smiling, Honecker responded with a Marxist-Leninist salute. That morning, the galleries were jammed with over a hundred supporters of the prosecution. They watched carefully as Erich Mielke – wearing dark sunglasses – hobbled into the courtroom on a stick, followed by Hans Albrecht, a District Party Secretary, who claimed to be so deaf he couldn’t follow proceedings. Former Prime Minister Willi Stoph was excused, having suffered a stroke the night before.